

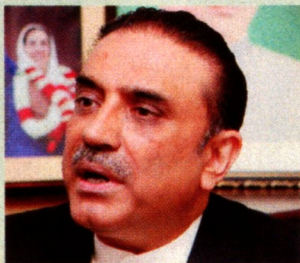
Holding The Cards

The eight leaders who will call the shots in Pakistan and their likely gameplans



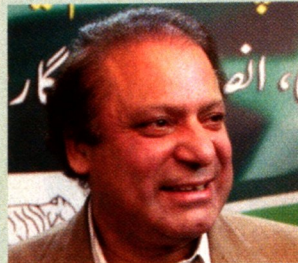
PERVEZ MUSHARRAF

Though weakened after the elections, as President he still has the power to dissolve Parliament and dismiss the prime minister. He may exploit the differences between PPP and PML(N) and thwart attempts to oust him.



ASIF ALI ZARDARI

Although not part of Parliament yet, the head of the single largest party will determine the prime minister. His Achilles' heel is his reputation for corruption and PPP rank and file's desperation to get back into power.



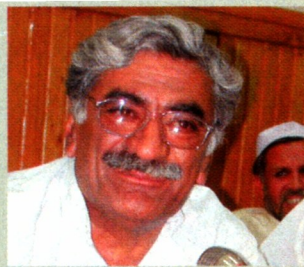
NAWAZ SHARIF

Also sitting outside Parliament, PML(N)'s gains position him as the real king-maker. His unbending stance on Musharraf and restoration of judiciary project him as a difficult partner, but his eyes are already on the next polls.



GENERAL ASHFAQ KAYANI

The new Chief of Army Staff has shown by a hands-off approach in the elections that he would like to see the military out of politics. He may have kept away from Musharraf's policies but may not like to see him humiliated and ousted.



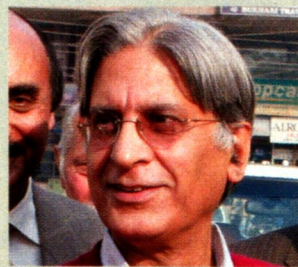
ASFANDIYAR WALI

The ANP chief has seen his party bounce back strongly after the disaster of the 2002 elections and will control the coalition in the troubled NWFP and may have a say at the federal level as well.



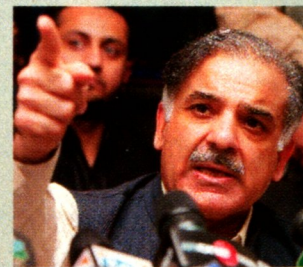
ALTAF HUSSAIN

The self-exiled MQM head is not part of Parliament but his pro-Musharraf party has substantial seats in the National and Sindh Assemblies, and controls Pakistan's commercial hub Karachi.



AITZAZ AHSAN

A leading light of PPP, the Supreme Court Bar Association President has led the movement for restoration of judiciary. He may prove to be a thorn in the side of Zardari should the latter play ball with Musharraf.



SHAHBAZ SHARIF

Not part of the contest this time round, the brother of former prime minister Nawaz Sharif and former chief minister of Punjab could easily emerge as the strongman of the biggest province once again.

Text by Hasan Zaidi

of Musharraf and his establishment.

Public anger at the state of economic affairs only added to the discontent brewing since the judicial crisis began last March which had severely dented Musharraf's popularity. As it is, a significant segment of the population viewed military operations in Balochistan and the North West Frontier Province (NWFP) as unjustified. With the spate of suicide bombings, that the Government admitted were a consequence of military operations against militants, a general feeling of

insecurity had gripped the country. A slew of opinion polls indicated that Musharraf's personal popularity was at an all-time low. The sacking of "independent-minded" judges, draconian curbs on the electronic media and the crackdown on the lawyers in the wake of imposition of Emergency in November may have been the last straw for the voters. And then came Bhutto's assassination.

With many, including PPP, holding the establishment responsible for the charismatic leader's death, it would

seem in retrospect that Musharraf's allies did not stand a chance. But even so, many were expecting the results to be "engineered" as most previous polls had been in Pakistan. Remarkably, however, it seems that the elections were conducted in a free and fair manner. Some quarters attribute it to the deliberate effort by the new Chief of Army Staff General Ashfaq Pervez Kayani to distance the army from politics. With intelligence agencies getting strict orders from the top to stay out of civilian politics, it seems the will to rig